Steven Boada, Ph.D

Basic Information

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Professional Experience

Activision Publishing, Inc. Boulder, Colorado

Lead Data Scientist, Gameplay **March, 2026 - Present**

As part of the game science team, I lead data science strategy and cross-functional analytics initiatives to improve gameplay systems and player experience across Call of Duty. In this role, I:

- Define and prioritize high-impact analytics initiatives with design leadership, identifying opportunities to improve gameplay systems and drive measurable engagement outcomes.
- Drive cross-functional analytical efforts to understand how gameplay systems (maps, modes, weapons, communication systems, etc.) influence player behavior and top-line KPIs, translating insights into actionable design recommendations.
- Own experimentation strategy for gameplay features, guiding the design and evaluation of A/B tests, statistical models, and large-scale player behavior analyses.
- Champion gameplay measurement strategy and data quality, partnering with engineering to improve telemetry coverage, instrumentation, and analytical reliability.
- Elevate team analytical capability by mentoring data scientists, reviewing experimental designs and analyses, and promoting best practices in experimentation, statistics, and data storytelling.

Senior Data Scientist, Gameplay **January, 2024 - 2026**

- Restarted advanced, gameplay analytics support for partner studios and on-going Call of Duty launches.
- Highlighted Project: Led the design and analysis of controller advantage which resulted in a rework of the controller aim assist system in Black Ops 7 (2025).

Senior Machine Learning Engineer **January, 2021 - 2024**

- Designed, built, and maintained ML infrastructure and tools, including autoML, CI/CD (Jenkins, GitHub Actions), model tracking (MLflow), and orchestration (Airflow) to support data-driven decision-making.
- Crafted and implemented policy for external data ingestion and retention to ensure accessibility and proper data stewardship across the organization.
- Developed near-realtime applications (via Spark streaming) to identify and mitigate in-game cheating and malicious behaviors, achieving action times in the low 10s of seconds.
- Spearheaded the transition of ML infrastructure from AWS to GCP/GCS, optimizing scalability and performance.
- Created machine learning models focused on customer conversion, churn prediction, and behavioral segmentation using survival analysis, clustering, and tree-based techniques.
- Managed the day to day of a small team of junior data scientists to design, develop, and deploy recommendation systems that were integrated into Modern Warfare 2 (2022) and Modern Warfare 3 (2023).

Insight Data Science New York, New York

Fellow **January, 2020 - 2021**

- Completed a data science bootcamp focused on transitioning academics into the tech industry, working on real-world data problems.
- Built a random forest model in Python to prioritize NYC restaurant inspections, improving violation detection by 2.5% and identifying critical issues up to 7 days earlier through an AWS-deployed API.

Skills

Machine Learning: Linear Models, Decision Trees, SVM, Clustering, Deep Learning, Survival Analysis
CI/CD: Jenkins, Airflow, Docker
Software and Computing: Open Source Contributor, Python, DataBricks, MLFlow, SQL, AWS/GCP, Spark, etc.
Leadership: Experience organizing and leading workshops and collaboration meetings, Teaching and mentoring junior team members, Eagle Scout.

Education

Texas A&M University, College Station, Texas

- Ph.D, Physics (astronomy focus), 2016

The University of Tennessee, Knoxville, Tennessee

- M.S., Physics (astronomy focus), 2009
- B.S., Physics, 2007